



GEORGE MATHEN, also famous as the drummer of the rock band Lounge Piranha, uses allegory to get the message across. Based in Bangalore, he has almost eliminated the use of words in his novel, *Moonward*, which deals with existential angst.

MATHEN'S BOOK *MOONWARD* IS COMIC-BASED, WHILE GHOSH'S (BELOW) *TIMES NEW ROMAN AND COUNTRY-MEN* COMPRISES POSTCARDS

collective, Inverted Commas, which has not only worked with the population council and NACO to bring out a series of comics on HIV/AIDS in Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata and Hyderabad, but has created what are known as comics cards for illiterate women, which are used by NGOs to spread the word in villages regarding disability, self-health practices and sanitation.

Indian comics, even for their entertainment quotient, have always been a pale shadow of their Western or Far-eastern counterparts. While the Manga movement in Japan was taking place and France was bringing out stellar graphic novels, Indian comics' best bet was *Amar Chitra Katha*, *Tinkle* and *Chacha Chaudhary*. It was just about five years ago that Virgin Comics made an entry into the Indian market and now there is a variety of indigenous players. But comics were never considered a communication tool before.

Sharma, for example, believes in what he terms as comics-based jour-

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VISHWAJYOTI GHOSH'S next graphic novel about three young men in the middle of political turmoil and corruption in the 1970s is called *Delhi Calm* and is due to be published by HarperCollins India later this year.

nalism. He enjoys an iconic status among India's social comics artists and has been in the business of rural pictorial communication for a decade. He has not only been a part of a comics anthology, featuring India's development through comics in the last 60 years, he has also started his comic magazine series, *Devcom*. Its first issue featured graphic renditions of Kashmir militancy, the Singur Nano plant fiasco, Nandigram, the ill-effects of tourism in Goa and about six other such stories. It is already being sold from alternative bookstores, through NGOs and online networks. Priced at Rs 100, the first

issue had 64 pages. "But our next issue, which has already been compiled, has 94 pages and about six 15-page stories," says Sharma. He plans to start a certificate course in comics-based journalism and is already in talks with Guwahati University and Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar Marathwada University, Aurangabad.

Sharma is, however, one of the more resourceful artists. Many comics artists have already started their ventures, and have had to backtrack, either because the market was too premature, or there was a lack of funds. Sarnath Banerjee's publishing house, Phantomville, is an example.